

D034

Systems Management and School Operations

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

To add a 30-minute intervention block, a principal at a school with a new front entrance moves the start of the day 30 minutes earlier. Soon after, bus routes shared with the high school fail, and many students arrive late, missing the block. The staff supports the intervention idea. What leadership lesson does this show?

- A. Intervention blocks never work.
- B. Changes in one part of the system affect others; the leader should have mapped effects on transportation before changing the bell time.
- C. The bus company alone is responsible for the problem.
- D. The staff should have been more supportive.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Before moving all art classes to a new building across campus, what should a systems-thinking leader do?

- A. Identify connected effects, such as passing times, supervision, special education services and supply delivery, before deciding.
- B. Assume no effect, since art is only one department.
- C. Move the classes and fix problems as they come.
- D. Ask only the art teachers.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A school improvement plan, printed on glossy paper for the open house, says: “Goal: Improve math achievement. Strategy: Better teaching.” Enrollment rose 5% this year. What most needs to be added?

- A. Specific action steps with owners, timelines, resources and measurable targets tied to baseline data.
- B. More goals in other subjects.
- C. A more attractive layout.
- D. Nothing; broad goals give staff freedom.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A high school with a new career center sets a goal to raise its four-year graduation rate. The principal wants to know by November whether the plan is on track. The district also tracks bus ridership. Which indicator should she monitor?

- A. Last year's graduation rate.
- B. Bus ridership numbers.
- C. The graduation rate itself.
- D. Ninth-grade attendance and course-passing rates each grading period.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which of these is a lagging indicator for a reading improvement plan?

- A. Attendance at the reading intervention.
- B. The percent of students proficient on the spring state reading test.
- C. Monthly progress-monitoring scores.
- D. Weekly minutes of independent reading.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A principal who recently finished a leadership fellowship wants to introduce a new morning advisory period to reduce tardies across a school of 1,200 students. The school has a new PA system. What is the best way to begin?

- A. Pilot it and expand regardless of the results.
- B. Launch it school-wide on Monday.
- C. Pilot it with a few advisory groups, predict the effect on tardies, study the data, and adjust before expanding.
- D. Announce it on the new PA system and assume it will work.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A pilot of a new homework policy was predicted to raise completion by 20%. It raised completion by only 3%, and teachers found it hard to manage. What is the appropriate Act step?

- A.** Adapt the policy based on what was learned, or abandon it, then run another small cycle.
- B.** Stop all improvement work, since tests always fail.
- C.** Report 20% improvement, since that was the prediction.
- D.** Adopt it school-wide as planned.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A school where 40% of families speak Spanish at home sends a notice about new pickup procedures only as an English email. The school has a well-designed logo and newsletter template. Many families miss the change. How should the communication system be improved?

- A.** Redesign the newsletter template.
- B.** Send it in Spanish only.
- C.** Send the English email twice.
- D.** Send the message in English and Spanish through several channels, such as text and email, state clearly what families must do, and provide a way to ask questions.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A district office with a new conference room is choosing a learning management system. One vendor gave an impressive demo and is used by a nearby district. The district's student information system is five years old. What should happen before purchase?

- A.** Replace the student information system first, since it is five years old.
- B.** Buy the vendor with the best demo.
- C.** Define needs with users, confirm it integrates with the current student information system, and review the vendor's student-data privacy terms.
- D.** Buy it because the nearby district uses it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

When building the master schedule at a school with a new auditorium, the principal learns that the only intervention reading section conflicts with the only section of band, and most students who need intervention are in band. Senior teachers prefer their current periods. What principle should guide the fix?

- A. Keep senior teachers' periods, since seniority comes first.
- B. Drop band for those students permanently.
- C. Hold band in the new auditorium.
- D. Build the schedule around student needs, so students can get intervention without losing band.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A school's emergency plan, bound in a red binder and stored in the main office, describes lockdown and evacuation steps in detail. The school has a newly paved parking lot. The plan has never been drilled or shared with local fire and police. What is the biggest gap?

- A. Nothing; a written plan is enough.
- B. Preparedness: staff and students need drills and training, and the plan must be coordinated with local responders.
- C. The response steps need more detail.
- D. The binder should be stored in a different color.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

After a storm damages a school, the principal arranges counseling, temporary classrooms and a plan to resume classes. Which phase of emergency management is this?

- A. Response.
- B. Preparedness.
- C. Recovery.
- D. Prevention and mitigation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

To add a 30-minute intervention block, a principal at a school ~~with a new front entrance~~ moves the start of the day 30 minutes earlier. Soon after, bus routes shared with the high school fail, and many students arrive late, missing the block. ~~The staff supports the intervention idea.~~ What leadership lesson does this show?

Target word: lesson **Decides:** A schedule change affected transportation, an interdependent system.

A	Absolute language	The block failed because of a system effect, not the idea.
B	Correct	Systems thinking anticipates ripple effects.
C	Adjacent category	Blames one part instead of seeing the connection.
D	Camouflage	Staff already supported it; that did not decide the failure.

2. Answer A Concept 1 • transfer

Before moving all art classes to a new building across campus, what should a systems-thinking leader do?

Target word: pre-change step **Decides:** Map which other parts of the school the change will affect.

A	Correct	Anticipating interdependencies prevents new problems.
B	Absolute language	Even one department connects to others.
C	Inverted operation	Reacts after the fact instead of anticipating.
D	Dropped element	Leaves out other affected groups.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A school improvement plan, ~~printed on glossy paper for the open house~~, says: "Goal: Improve math achievement. Strategy: Better teaching." ~~Enrollment rose 5% this year.~~ What most needs to be added?

Target word: missing plan elements **Decides:** Goals need specific strategies, owners, timelines, resources and measures.

A	Correct	Alignment makes the plan actionable and measurable.
B	Adjacent category	Adds goals without fixing this one.
C	Camouflage	Format does not make a plan actionable.
D	Inverted operation	Vague plans cannot be monitored.

4. Answer D Concept 3

A high school ~~with a new career center~~ sets a goal to raise its four-year graduation rate. The principal wants to know by November whether the plan is on track. ~~The district also tracks bus ridership.~~ Which indicator should she monitor?

Target word: early indicator **Decides:** A leading indicator predicts graduation.

A	Wrong stem number	Past results, not a current signal.
B	Camouflage	Not tied to the graduation goal.
C	Inverted operation	A lagging indicator known only after the fact.
D	Correct	Leading indicators predict graduation and allow early action.

5. Answer B Concept 3 • transfer

Which of these is a lagging indicator for a reading improvement plan?

Target word: pick the lagging indicator **Decides:** Results reported after the fact.

A	Adjacent category	A process measure that leads outcomes.
B	Correct	An end-of-year outcome.
C	Inverted operation	A leading indicator.
D	Confusion set	An early process signal, which is leading.

6. Answer C Concept 4

A principal ~~who recently finished a leadership fellowship~~ wants to introduce a new morning advisory period to reduce tardies across a school of 1,200 students. ~~The school has a new PA system.~~ What is the best way to begin?

Target word: rollout approach **Decides:** Test small with a prediction, study results, then act.

A	Inverted operation	Ignores the Study and Act steps.
B	Dropped element	Skips the small test and study.
C	Correct	A PDSA cycle tests on a small scale first.
D	Camouflage	Answers the PA detail; no test or study.

7. Answer A Concept 4 • transfer

A pilot of a new homework policy was predicted to raise completion by 20%. It raised completion by only 3%, and teachers found it hard to manage. What is the appropriate Act step?

Target word: Act step after a weak result **Decides:** Adapt or abandon based on the study.

A	Correct	Act uses the Study results.
B	Absolute language	A weak test is information, not a reason to quit.
C	Wrong stem number	Reports the prediction, not the result.
D	Inverted operation	Scales a change the data did not support.

8. Answer D Concept 5

A school where 40% of families speak Spanish at home sends a notice about new pickup procedures only as an English email. ~~The school has a well-designed logo and newsletter template.~~ Many families miss the change. How should the communication system be improved?

Target word: system improvement **Decides:** Messages must reach every audience in usable form and allow response.

A	Camouflage	Design does not fix language or channel gaps.
B	Inverted operation	Swaps which families are left out.
C	Adjacent category	Repeats the same barrier.
D	Correct	Accessible, actionable and two-way.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A district office ~~with a new conference room~~ is choosing a learning management system. One vendor gave an impressive demo and is used by a nearby district. The district's student information system is five years old. What should happen before purchase?

Target word: pre-purchase step **Decides:** Needs analysis, interoperability and data privacy checks.

A	Wrong stem number	Age alone does not show the system must go.
B	Dropped element	Skips needs analysis and checks.
C	Correct	Fit, interoperability and privacy decide success.
D	Adjacent category	Another district's choice does not show fit here.

10. Answer D Concept 7

When building the master schedule at a school ~~with a new auditorium~~, the principal learns that the only intervention reading section conflicts with the only section of band, and most students who need intervention are in band. Senior teachers prefer their current periods. What principle should guide the fix?

Target word: scheduling principle **Decides:** Schedule around student needs first.

A	Inverted operation	Puts adult preference ahead of student access.
B	Absolute language	Removes access instead of solving the conflict.
C	Camouflage	Room change does not fix the time conflict.
D	Correct	The schedule allocates time and staff to priorities.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A school's emergency plan, ~~bound in a red binder and stored in the main office~~, describes lockdown and evacuation steps in detail. ~~The school has a newly paved parking lot.~~ The plan has never been drilled or shared with local fire and police. What is the biggest gap?

Target word: gap in the plan **Decides:** No preparedness activity: drills, training, or coordination with responders.

A	Absolute language	Plans must be practiced and coordinated.
B	Correct	A plan never practiced or shared is not ready.
C	Adjacent category	Response is already covered; preparedness is missing.
D	Camouflage	Storage is not the gap.

12. Answer C Concept 8 • transfer

After a storm damages a school, the principal arranges counseling, temporary classrooms and a plan to resume classes. Which phase of emergency management is this?

Target word: name the phase **Decides:** Restoring operations and well-being after the event.

A	Confusion set	Response is the immediate action during the event.
B	Confusion set	Preparedness is planning and drills before the event.
C	Correct	Restoring learning and well-being after an emergency.
D	Inverted operation	Those reduce risk before an event.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	3	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	9	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	3	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Systems thinking	A school is a set of interdependent parts; a change in one part (schedule, staffing, transportation) ripples into others, so leaders look for root causes, leverage points and unintended effects.	Fixing one symptom in isolation and creating a new problem elsewhere.	A change in one department that affects another.
2	An aligned strategic plan	A data-based strategic plan links each goal to strategies and action steps with owners, timelines, resources and measures of progress.	Listing goals with no owner, deadline, or measure.	A plan that states intentions but not who, when or how measured.
3	Leading vs. lagging indicators	Lagging indicators report results after the fact (annual test scores, graduation rates); leading indicators are earlier signals that predict them (attendance, course grades, interim assessments) and allow mid-course correction.	Monitoring a plan only with end-of-year results.	Measures chosen for tracking progress during the year.
4	The PDSA improvement cycle	Plan a change with a prediction, Do it on a small scale, Study the results against the prediction, then Act by adopting, adapting or abandoning before scaling up.	Launching school-wide without a small test, or skipping the Study step.	A new practice and a question about how to roll it out.
5	Two-way, actionable communication systems	Effective school communication reaches each audience in accessible formats and languages, tells people what to do with the information, and includes ways to respond.	One-way announcements in a single channel and language.	A message to families or community and whether it can be understood and acted on.
6	Selecting operational technology	Choose operational systems (student information, learning management, communication) from a needs analysis, checking interoperability with existing systems and student-data privacy terms before purchase.	Buying the most popular or feature-rich system first and discovering fit problems later.	A technology purchase decision.
7	The master schedule as resource allocation	The master schedule allocates the school's scarcest resources—time, staff and space—and should be built around student needs and priorities, such as intervention time, before adult preferences.	Building the schedule around staff seniority or last year's pattern.	A scheduling decision that affects access to courses or support.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
8	Emergency operations planning	School emergency plans cover prevention and mitigation, preparedness (including drills and training), response, and recovery, and are coordinated with local responders.	Treating the plan as response-only, or writing it without drills or outside partners.	A safety plan and a question about what is missing.

Course scope (public description): Systems management and school operations instruct candidates on the operational aspects of school leadership that are essential to developing, monitoring, and evaluating school management, school systems, and services that address and support the needs of students and school personnel. Topics presented in this course include systems thinking; development, implementation, and evaluation of data-based strategic planning; and school improvement processes. Candidates will evaluate the use of appropriate operational technology and the development of communications systems that provide actionable information to internal and external stakeholders for use in classroom and school improvement and community engagement. Each of these topics emphasizes the importance of efficiently and effectively managing school resources to build, maintain, and evaluate a cohesive system of academic and organizational supports, services, extracurricular activities, and accommodations to meet the full range of needs for each student. Prerequisites for this course: Leadership Foundations and Ethics and School Law.